

Learning is most effective when it is purposeful, organized, and based on real-life experience. However, none of that can occur until a student's most basic needs are met first. Maslow (1943) suggested that human beings need to satisfy basic physiological and safety needs before belonging, esteem, and self-actualization. You cannot teach a hungry, unsafe, or emotionally unsettled child, no matter how well the lesson is designed. I need to see the whole child before I can teach.

My teaching philosophy is rooted in both the behaviorist and constructivist theories. Skinner (1938) knew that lasting learning is built through continuous reinforcement and feedback loops. Dewey (1938) contends that real learning comes from experiencing things rather than being taught passively, and Piaget (1952) demonstrates that cognitive development occurs when a learner's current knowledge is challenged and reorganized. Constructivism is the most compatible with my approach because learners actively construct knowledge instead of passively receiving it (Harasim, 2017). My belief is that knowledge is best developed through cooperation, creativity, and interaction. Productive struggle, however, is only possible when students feel safe enough to try, fail, and try again. Vygotsky (1978) acknowledged that the environment a teacher creates is not a background to learning but a condition for it. I expect, respect, and need mistakes in my classroom because a wrong answer is proof of thinking.

Data and assessment are the center of my teaching. The best way to see learning is when a student can talk through their logic, work through a problem independently, and begin to correct their own mistakes with more and more confidence. In digital environments, assessment must go beyond testing and have opportunities to create projects, engage in discussions, and provide feedback that helps learner development while giving educators meaningful data to analyze. This shows academic, social, and emotional growth work in tandem, and that is the kind of growth that data alone cannot fully capture. As AI grows in education, it should enhance a teacher's ability to observe, personalize, and deepen learning, not reduce it to what is easiest to measure. My goal is to design digital learning environments that purposefully integrate technology and honor the needs of every learner.